

Wondering whether you're lonely, or just alone

8 findings · 14-step checklist · 1 myth · 7 sources · cheatgrid.com

Loneliness can sit right beside a partner and a full house. It tracks **how close the people around you feel**, not how many of them there are or who's home tonight.

THE GOAL

You're working out which one this is. Put a single word to the feeling right now, before you decide it counts as loneliness or doesn't.

CHECKLIST

The flat, cut-off feeling hits, whether you're in a full house or an empty one, and you catch yourself trying to decide if it even counts as loneliness.

- ☐ Name the feeling in one word right now (flat, cut off, empty) instead of jumping straight to 'I'm lonely' or 'I'm fine.'
- ☐ If you're with people right now, **stay in the conversation** instead of reaching for your phone: ask the nearest person one real follow-up question.
- ☐ Listen for one new detail in their answer you didn't already know, so you're checking the connection, not counting heads.
- ☐ If you're alone right now, do one thing that moves you toward someone before tonight ends: text, call, or set a time to see them.
- ☐ Aim that message or call at one specific person, not a group chat.
- ☐ Write down, in one line, which relationship this feeling is really about right now, a partner, a friend, family, not 'everyone.'
- ☐ Ask directly: is this about how many people are around, or whether they know what's going on with you? Answer in one sentence.
- ☐ If you named someone you feel distant from despite being close, write down one honest thing you haven't told them yet.
- ☐ If you're reading someone's quietness or distance as rejection, name one other explanation (they're busy, tired, distracted) before acting on it.
- ☐ If you're about to judge your character ('I'm just bad at this'), name one specific thing you did instead, like talking mostly about yourself.
- ☐ If you're about to write the feeling off as dramatic or ungrateful, don't: jot a placeholder note, a date and a word, for later.
- ☐ Before this moment ends, **send one small kind message** to somebody else, like a quick 'thinking of you,' instead of only turning inward.
- ☐ Set a stopping point for tonight, like when you finish this task or when you go to bed, and stop there.
- ☐ Write one line about what you noticed this time, so next time you're not starting from scratch.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Feeling lonely goes with doing **less** for others, a small but real dip. That dip isn't proof you're broken.
- 2 Having a partner doesn't rule out being lonely: roughly **1 in 6** married people, in one study of older couples, describe real loneliness inside the relationship.
- 3 Loneliness inside a relationship doesn't stay contained to your own mood: research links it to lower relational well-being for both partners, and for men, to their partner's sexual well-being too.

What the feeling itself changes, without you noticing

KNOW

Feeling lonely goes with doing **less** for others, a small but real dip. That dip isn't proof you're broken.

The link showed up across dozens of studies and different ways of measuring it, though how big it looked depended on the measurement used. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

Feeling lonely can make you size up other people as less fair and less trustworthy than you otherwise would.

The fairness result held up after depression and life satisfaction were factored in; the trust result mostly did not. [Source 2](#)

WATCH

After a long stretch of feeling cut off, ordinary moments start reading as more threatening than they actually are.

It shows up as reading small things, like **a pause or a lack of a smile**, as proof something is wrong. [Source 3](#)

What actually decides whether you're lonely

KNOW

Being physically alone and feeling lonely are different things: neither is always a sign of the other.

The gap runs both directions: some people alone a lot feel fine, and some people rarely alone still feel cut off. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Having a partner doesn't rule out being lonely: roughly **1 in 6** married people, in one study of older couples, describe real loneliness inside the relationship.

Marriage buffers loneliness on average, but that average hides a real minority for whom it doesn't. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

Loneliness inside a relationship doesn't stay contained to your own mood: research links it to lower relational well-being for both partners, and for men, to their partner's sexual well-being too.

Naming it to your partner is worth doing, since the pattern held for both of you, not just whoever feels lonelier. [Source 4](#)

What helps, and what you can stop chasing

RULE

A study of older adults found that adding more close friends stopped making much difference to loneliness once people already had around four.

The same study found a similar leveling-off for low mood and anxiety, not just loneliness. [Source 5](#)

DO

Doing something kind for someone else lowers loneliness more than looking after yourself instead does, according to research comparing the pair of approaches directly.

People assigned to help others felt less lonely afterward than people assigned to look after themselves instead. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

I must be lonely because I just don't have good social skills.

ACTUALLY

There's no consistent evidence that lonely people generally lack social skills. When researchers tested social skill directly, the problem was **anxiety getting in the way**, not a missing skill. [Source 7](#)

Sources

1. <http://www.neuronauka-spoleczna.pl/wp-content/uploads/2024/10/Malon-et-al.-2024.pdf>
2. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC7596507/>
3. <https://www.socialconnectionguidelines.org/en/evidence-briefs/how-can-people-cope-with-loneliness>
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5. <https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/ageing-and-society/article/friendships-loneliness-and-psychological-wellbeing-in-older-adults-a-limit-to-the-benefit-of-the-number-of-friends/27B597694C72769283D6E666939F7C15>
6. <https://www.ucla.edu/research/article/loneliness>
7. <https://www.mentalfloss.com/science/mental-health/lonely-people-have-social-skills-theyre-just-too-anxious-use-them>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Loneliness and connection at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](https://cheatgrid.com)